SEND WITH THE SCRIPT

Self-recording guide

Reality-TV confessional style: you sit and talk to the camera, deadpan. No interviewer, so prop up your own phone, or let whoever sent you this hold it, and record it in five minutes whenever you have a free moment.

Setup

- **Nobody films you.** Prop your phone horizontal against a stack of books or a mug, at face height, about an arm's length away. Sit in a chair against a plain wall or a bookshelf.
- **Light:** face a window or a lamp. Don't sit with a window behind you.
- **Eyeline:** look just to the side of the lens, as if a producer is sitting next to the phone. Glancing at the lens once or twice is fine.
- **Tone:** deadpan beats hammy. You are a sincere person who has nothing to hide and is slightly annoyed to be asked.

Recording

- **The script:** read it from a second screen or a printout taped just under the phone. The *(beat)* and *(pause)* marks are where the laughs live. Hold them longer than feels natural.
- **Takes:** two max. Send the slightly flubbed one. Don't edit anything.
- **Length:** 60 to 90 seconds. Start recording, wait two seconds, begin. Stop two seconds after the last line.
- **Send it:** text or AirDrop the raw video to whoever sent you the script. They add the title card and load it onto the classroom laptop.

Making the script yours

Words in [brackets] are adjustable. The box at the top of your script sorts them: a few **must match the case file** (your clothing color, the time, a shoe size), because the kids cross-check what you say against printed evidence; if one of those is wrong for you, tell whoever sent you this before recording and it gets changed everywhere. Your clothing color only has to be true for "yesterday": wear it on camera if you can, but the lines work if you can't. The rest is flavor. Swap in your real life, your real subject, your real habits. True details get the biggest laughs.

The ask (email or text to each suspect)

Subject: 5 minutes of acting for the 4th grade Halloween party?

Hi [Name],

Mrs. Driscoll's class Halloween party on Oct 30 is a whodunit, and the kids are going to investigate four staff "suspects." Would you be one of the three who record a statement? All it takes is a 90-second video of yourself that you can record alone on your phone whenever you have a free minute. No one films you, no one edits you, and you don't need to attend the party.

Attached is your script. It's a monologue, so just talk to the camera. Quick tips:
• Phone horizontal, propped at face height, plain wall behind you
• Look just beside the lens, like a producer is sitting there
• Deadpan. Sincere. Slightly annoyed to be asked.
• Hold the pauses. Two takes max. Send me the raw video by [Oct 23].

The kids will watch it on the projector during the party and, I promise, lose their minds. Thank you!

[Your name] · [room parent for Mrs. Driscoll's class] · [phone]

The Custodian gets a different ask: "You're a suspect who declined to comment. That's it. That's the whole job. Please act shifty in the hallway on Oct 30."

VIDEO 2 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 2

VIDEO 2 — THE GYM TEACHER

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec · Zero information. Genuinely does not understand squishies and is a little offended to be asked.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 2 · THE GYM TEACHER · 11:05 AM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Must match the case file: you were "in the building" at [2:15], you own something [orange] (the thief's color), and you genuinely don't get squishies. Wear the color on camera if you can; if you can't, the line still works, because you only claim you wore it yesterday. Don't swap the color on your own; it's the same color on the ransom note, the posters, and the case file. If it should change, the room parent changes it everywhere.
- Linked to another clue: the [foam avocado] squishy. The mummy's witness statement and the Chief's confession both mention the avocado one. Change it only if the room parent changes those too.
- Free to change: [dodgeball] (whatever unit you're actually teaching), [inflating/deflating things], [jump rope], [school color]. Swap in your real gym life.
- Keep exactly: "I just don't understand the obsession these days." The kids will quote it.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Whistle around your neck if you have one. Look just beside the camera. You are missing a [dodgeball] unit for this.)

I'm missing a [dodgeball] unit for this, so.

Where was I at [2:15] yesterday? Gym. Where I always am. [Inflating things. Deflating things.] The cycle of life.

Did I go near Mrs. Driscoll's room? I go near every room. The hallway is my warm-up lap.

(long sigh)

Okay. Can I say something about these squishies? I don't see what these kids see in squishies anyway. You squeeze it. It goes back. You squeeze it again. It goes back again. That's it. That's the whole thing. I just don't understand the obsession these days.

(beat)

So no, I didn't take that jar. Why would I take a whole jar of something I don't understand? You want to steal something, steal a good [jump rope]. Those are valuable.

(pause. If you're wearing it, look down at your shirt. If not, shrug.)

And yes, I was wearing [orange] yesterday. It's a [school color]. Half this building wears [orange]. (look back up) Are you writing that down?

(beat)

Last thing. Whoever has those squishies: there's a whole class of kids out there who can run a mile but can't go a day without squeezing a [foam avocado]. Think about that.

(stand up)

I'm going back to the gym.

(Walk out of frame. Stop recording.)